together and redraft Article 1 to read: 'Bharat shall be a Union of States'. The use of Bharat at the G20 summit was clearly an impropriety and ought not to have been done when our constitutional English name continues to be India.

In the past, several cities have been renamed. But these were only symbolic and not a substitute for real and substantial change. Our national fervour came to the fore when removing English names, but there was no fervour in improving civic amenities. An unfortunate example of the increasing resort to symbolism is the proposed replacement of the Indian Penal Code with Bharatiya Nyay Sanhita Bill, 2023. Nothing significant will be achieved unless we focus on improving the criminal justice system, particularly when half a million of our citizens languish as undertrials.

India rightly aspires to be a great economic power and changing our identity to Bharat will not in the least help us become a five trillion-dollar economy or resolve major problems facing the nation. The cost of replacing India with Bharat will be huge with no corresponding benefit. Sadly, replacing India with Bharat only symbolises a special type of nationalism that may pay political dividends but will cost the country dear. ■

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By **PAVAN K. VARMA**

CALL ME BY BOTH NAMES

'INDIA', 'BHARAT' AND 'HINDUSTAN' HAVE FOR LONG BEEN USED INTERCHANGEABLY AND HAVE A LONGER HISTORY THAN ANYONE CAN REMEMBER. WHY RAKE UP THE MATTER NOW?

The iconic writer from Karnataka, U.R. Ananthamurthy (1932-2014), whom I had the great privilege of knowing, once quipped to me that the entire controversy over renaming Bangalore to Bengaluru—which he had proposed in 2006—was amusingly inane since for ordinary Kannadigas, Bangalore had always been Bengaluru. I suppose the same irrefutable logic would apply to the name changes of Calcutta to Kolkata, Madras to Chennai, and Cawnpore to Kanpur.

The earlier names of these cities were given by the British, and the new ones were what they were always referred to by most locals. To that extent, the reversal was relevant. Countries, too, have changed their names. To cite a few examples, Turkey in 2021 renamed itself as Türkiye Cumhuriyeti, Republic of Türkiye. Interestingly, one of the reasons was that a Google search invariably also showed Turkey as the bird eaten in the West on Christmas, and in America also on Thanksgiving! Earlier, in 1972, the British colonial name of Ceylon was changed to Sri Lanka; in 1980, Rhodesia rejected its British name to become Zimbabwe; and in 1989, Burma jettisoned its colonial baggage by renaming itself Myanmar.

But in the new controversy about the government's alleged intention to change the name of India to Bharat, the key question is: what are we reclaiming to throw out the other? Was India the name given to us by our British masters? The historical evidence would indicate otherwise. Noted historian Dr Upinder Singh, in her magnum opus, *A History of Ancient and Medieval India: From the Stone Age to the 12th Century,* writes that the words 'India', 'Hindu' and 'Hindustan' originate from the river Indus or Sindhu. Ancient Chinese sources refer to the land of 'Shen-tu'; Greek texts, starting with Megasthenes, who visited the court of Chandragupta Maurya in fourth century BCE, refer to the entire subcontinent as 'India', Persian inscriptions of the same vintage use the word 'Hindu' as one of the subject countries of